

How people shop through Instagram

Survey findings from 100 submissions

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100 submissions	62 buyer submissions	70% cite lack of trust
94 distinct respondent IDs	Bought at least occasionally	Across all submissions

Research question

What do people buy after discovering products on Instagram, how do they decide, and what prevents a purchase?

Main finding

The strongest recurring signal is a need for credible evidence before buying. Reviews/comments influence 42 of 62 buyers (67.7%), and a review community is the most selected proposed improvement (58 of 100 submissions).

Category finding

Accessories lead overall (26 of 62 buyers). Jewellery leads among female buyers (13 of 30); accessories and health & fitness lead among male buyers (15 and 12 of 32).

Product implication

Test whether real customer reviews, clear seller information and visible return policies help shoppers evaluate unfamiliar brands. These results support a prototype test, not a claim of product-market fit.

Scope

Self-reported responses to an Instagram-shopping form. The survey does not isolate independent sellers from ads for established retailers, or measure where checkout occurred.

Source: Instagram Shopping Research_Submissions_2026-10-01-2.csv. Collection timestamps: 20 September - 1 October 2026. Public report includes aggregated findings only.

Who responded and how often they buy

Group	Submissions	Buyers	Buyer share
Male	55	32	58.2%
Female	45	30	66.7%
Total	100	62	62.0%

A buyer is a submission selecting any frequency other than "never". Each submission is counted once within a group; repeated respondent IDs are retained in the main analysis.

Purchase frequency	Total	Male	Female
Never	38	23	15
Once in a while	50	23	27
Every one or two months	9	6	3
Very frequently	3	3	0

Shopping is mostly occasional. Fifty submissions report buying once in a while; only 12 report buying every one or two months or very frequently. The form does not define exact time periods for "once in a while" or "very frequently".

Age range as asked	Submissions	Buyers	Buyer share
18-25	39	25	64.1%
25-34	52	32	61.5%
35-45	9	5	55.6%

The sample is concentrated in ages 18-34 (91 submissions). Age bands overlap at age 25, so they are preserved exactly as selected. The 35-45 group is too small for a strong age comparison.

Geography: 66 submissions provide a city and 34 leave it blank. Normalizing spelling/case yields Hyderabad 23, Bengaluru 10, Kolkata 8, Gurugram 5 and Pune 4. Other reported locations account for 16 submissions. This is not a representative geographic sample.

What people buy: categories and gender

Predefined category selections among 62 buyers. Multiple selections are allowed. These are buyer mentions, not order counts, sales or spending.

Category	All buyers (62)	Male buyers (32)	Female buyers (30)
Accessories	26 (41.9%)	15 (46.9%)	11 (36.7%)
Jewellery	17 (27.4%)	4 (12.5%)	13 (43.3%)
Ethnic wear	16 (25.8%)	8 (25.0%)	8 (26.7%)
Western wear	16 (25.8%)	8 (25.0%)	8 (26.7%)
Health & fitness	15 (24.2%)	12 (37.5%)	3 (10.0%)
Home decor	12 (19.4%)	8 (25.0%)	4 (13.3%)
Handmade & crafts	10 (16.1%)	2 (6.2%)	8 (26.7%)
Footwear	8 (12.9%)	7 (21.9%)	1 (3.3%)

Female buyer pattern: Jewellery is the most selected category (43.3%), followed by accessories (36.7%). Ethnic wear, western wear and handmade/crafts each appear in 26.7% of female buyer submissions.

Male buyer pattern: Accessories lead (46.9%), followed by health & fitness (37.5%). Footwear appears more often among male buyers (21.9%) than female buyers (3.3%).

Shared interest: Ethnic wear and western wear each have eight male and eight female buyer mentions. The survey does not ask whether purchases are for the respondent or for someone else.

Additional free-text purchases: Kitchen appliances/cookware are mentioned in two submissions; unspecified clothes, organic skincare and a wellness retreat in one submission each. These are not merged into predefined category totals. A dumbbell mention elaborates on an existing health & fitness selection.

Data exception: one "never" submission also selects accessories. It is excluded from the buyer table. The raw accessory count across all submissions is 27; the buyer-only count is 26. No zero category should be interpreted as proof of no market demand.

Discovery, decisions and motivations

Discovery channel	Buyer mentions	% of 62 buyers
Ads	37	59.7%
Influencers / creators	26	41.9%
Friends / shared posts	21	33.9%
Explore page	19	30.6%
Brand pages followed	15	24.2%

Purchase decision factor	Buyer mentions	% of 62 buyers
Reviews/comments	42	67.7%
Product photos/videos	38	61.3%
Brand reputation	26	41.9%
Return policy	26	41.9%
Discounts	20	32.3%
Creator recommendation	12	19.4%

Discovery is not the same as persuasion. Creators appear in 26 discovery selections, but creator recommendations appear in 12 purchase-factor selections. This is an aggregate comparison, not a conversion funnel. Reviews and visuals are selected more often as purchase influences.

Underlying motivation	Buyer mentions	% of 62 buyers
Incidental buying prompted by ads	39	62.9%
Unique / handmade / personalised	22	35.5%
Support small businesses	14	22.6%
Detail / eco-friendly approach	14	22.6%

All tables allow multiple responses. Buyer-only motivations avoid interpreting answers from "never" submissions as evidence of actual shopping behavior.

Barriers and requested improvements

Barrier	All submissions (100)	Buyers (62)	Non-buyers (38)
Lack of trust	70	40 (64.5%)	30 (78.9%)
Not enough product information	42	31 (50.0%)	11 (28.9%)
Unclear return policy	41	29 (46.8%)	12 (31.6%)
Price is too high	29	25 (40.3%)	4 (10.5%)
Long delivery times	21	19 (30.6%)	2 (5.3%)
Complicated checkout	16	13 (21.0%)	3 (7.9%)

Trust remains central even after a purchase. It is selected by 40 of 62 buyers (64.5%) and 30 of 38 non-buyers (78.9%). Clear returns also matter: 29 of 62 buyers (46.8%) select unclear return policy as a barrier.

Proposed improvement	All (100)	Buyers (62)	Non-buyers (38)
Photo, video and text review community	58	34	24
One website to find Instagram sellers	35	27	8
Pinterest-like discovery experience	33	23	10

Community reviews lead the proposed options: 58 submissions overall, including 34 buyers (54.8%) and 24 non-buyers (63.2%). A seller directory attracts 27 buyers (43.5%), and Pinterest-like discovery 23 (37.1%).

What the written responses add: Comments describe worries about fake or missing reviews, seller authenticity, insecure external links, cash on delivery, and receiving the wrong item. Some describe checking Google or established retailers after Instagram discovery. These themes are qualitative, not separately quantified prevalence estimates.

A counterpoint worth testing: One written response prefers Instagram in its current form and questions turning it into a shopping experience. A separate shopping companion may suit some users better than changing their social feed.

Improvement options were prompted by the form. Selecting an option measures stated preference, not adoption, willingness to contribute reviews or willingness to pay.

What MuseMarket should test next

Evidence from the survey	Product hypothesis	How to test it
70 cite lack of trust; 42/62 buyers use reviews	Credible customer evidence helps evaluate unfamiliar sellers	Compare product evaluation with and without customer photos, review context and seller information. Measure confidence and seller click-through.
42 lack product information; 41 cite unclear returns	Structured details reduce uncertainty	Test cards showing price, materials, sizing, delivery and returns. Ask shoppers to identify what still prevents a decision.
58 select a review community	A review community can attract repeat use	Pilot reviews with real shoppers. Measure contribution rate, useful-review ratings and repeat visits.
Accessories lead overall; jewellery leads among female buyers	A focused category launch may be easier to validate	Test accessories and jewellery with separate shopper groups. Compare relevant-result rate and purchase intent.
35 select a directory; 33 select Pinterest-like discovery	Discovery adds value alongside trust information	Observe shoppers finding a product and seller. Measure search success, saves and return visits.

Recommended initial scope: A small, curated discovery experience with product details, transparent seller information and customer reviews. Seller verification should describe exactly what was checked; avoid implying a guarantee the product cannot provide.

Follow-up research: Interview recent buyers and people who abandoned a purchase. Ask them to walk through their last actual decision, including seller checks, checkout destination, spending, returns and whether the product was for themselves. Test the prototype using real tasks before expanding scope.

What this study cannot establish: Market size, sales by category, revenue opportunity, causality, representative gender preferences or product-market fit. No willingness-to-pay or behavioral adoption measure was collected.

Methodology and data quality

Source and timing. Analysis of all 100 rows in Instagram Shopping

Research_Submissions_2026-10-01-2.csv. Export timestamps span 20 September to 1 October 2026; the timezone of those timestamps is not supplied. The form was circulated by the project owner.

Recruitment channel distribution and sampling frame are unknown.

Unit of analysis. There are 100 unique submission IDs and 94 distinct respondent IDs. One respondent ID occurs six times and another twice. Repeated IDs contain conflicting city, age or gender information, so it is unclear whether these are repeat respondents or a shared-device effect. Main results count submissions, not 100 verified unique people.

Repeated-ID sensitivity check	All rows	First row / ID	Last row / ID
Base size	100	94	94
Buyer submissions	62	57	57
Lack of trust	70 (70.0%)	64 (68.1%)	64 (68.1%)
Review community preference	58 (58.0%)	52 (55.3%)	52 (55.3%)

Keeping only the earliest or latest row per respondent ID preserves the main trust and review-community signals. This is a sensitivity check, not a determination of the correct respondent count. Subgroup estimates can still shift when repeated IDs are removed.

Cleaning and counting. Whitespace is trimmed for frequency and city fields. City variants Bangalore/Bengaluru/Banglore and Gurgaon/Gurugram are combined. Fixed option labels are matched as complete phrases, so commas inside the accessories label are not mistaken for separate categories. Motivation counts use the four exported true/false option columns.

Denominators. Frequency, demographics, barriers and overall improvement preferences use 100 submissions. Buyer category, discovery, decision and motivation analyses use 62 buyer submissions. Gender category shares use 32 male and 30 female buyer submissions. Multi-select totals can exceed their denominator. Percentages are rounded to one decimal.

Missing and inconsistent answers. City is blank in 34 submissions. Product category is populated in 63 rows, including one "never" response; buyer categories exclude that row. Discovery and purchase-factor questions are populated in all 62 buyer rows. Motivation answers from non-buyers are excluded from buyer motivation analysis.

Interpretation and publication. This is exploratory, self-selected research with self-report and recall limitations. Gender is reported as supplied (male/female only in this dataset). Free-text themes are paraphrased without identifying details. No respondent IDs, individual records or exact quotations are published. All numerical findings come from the supplied CSV; product proposals are hypotheses derived from those findings.